Small steps

Explaining new ideas in manageable chunks

Use small steps when several interacting decisions make new content hard to follow. Teach a coherent component, rehearse it and then connect it to the next part.

How to do it well

1 Set the micro-goal. Signal the one small piece of learning students are about to tackle and link it to prior knowledge.

2 Model the step. Demonstrate clearly and think aloud so students see what success looks like and why the process works.

3 Guide immediate practice. Give students a supported attempt straight away using prompts, part-completed examples or peer rehearsal.

4 Check and correct. Gather responses from all students, diagnose patterns of error and reteach before mistakes become established.

5 Build to the next step. Move on when most are secure, connect the mastered component to the next and gradually combine steps into a complete process.

What this sounds like

“For this example, we are only choosing the correct equation. Once that decision is secure, we will substitute the values.”

Classroom example. For a multi-stage calculation, students first choose the relationship, then substitute values, then manage units. The teacher checks each consequential decision before combining the process. Once the separate components are secure, pupils complete a whole calculation with fewer cues. The small steps preserve the overall purpose of the method.

Top tips that make the technique work

Keep the whole idea visible. Students should know how the current step contributes to the complete process.

Make a step teachable. “Complete question one” is not a learning component; “choose the correct relationship” may be.

Check before adding a dependent step. An error in the first decision can make every later answer misleading.

Use immediate rehearsal. Do not save all student practice until the end of a long explanation.

Recombine deliberately. After components are secure, ask students to complete the process without separate cues for every move.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Use coherent micro-goals and consistent terminology.	Fragmenting the content until the overall meaning disappears.
Build back towards independent whole-task performance.	Equating small steps with slow teacher speech.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

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